

Session 16: How to Read an Ancient Text

Key Takeaways

- We can use three strategies to understand the literary design of a work: Identifying the contextual anchors (what the author assumes we know), identifying the literary units, and identifying repeated words.
- A “lead-word” is a significant repeated word in a text that helps us understand the meaning of the text.

Lessons in Literature

Literature is a form of literary communication through which an author conveys a “what” (the message) through a carefully and intentionally crafted “how” (an artistically formed/shaped literary work).

The poetics of biblical literature are the “how” of Israelite literature.

The unique set of literary techniques, conventions, and strategies employed by the biblical authors (narrative, poetry, and discourse) have a particular stylistic profile that is both similar to and different from other ancient Near Eastern literature.

Recommended Resources

- Robert Alter, [*The Art of Biblical Narrative*](#)
- Adele Berlin, [*Poetics and Interpretation of Biblical Narrative*](#)
- Shimon Bar-Efrat, [*Narrative Art in the Bible*](#)
- Meir Sternberg, [*The Poetics of Biblical Narrative*](#)

The Epic Literary Genre

This genre can be defined as a larger collection of smaller narratives interwoven with poems and genealogies and arranged into movements that exhibit a high degree of repetition and patterning.

Identifying Contextual Anchors

What does the author assume we know before we start reading this work? The opening words of biblical literary works usually give some indicator of the context within which to understand the text.

For example, Jonah 1:1-2 invites the reader into a set of hyperlinks related to the backstory of Jonah and of Nineveh.

Literary Analysis

Study the literary features of a book in order to determine the boundaries of literary units (see David A. Dorsey, [The Literary Structure of the Old Testament: A Commentary on Genesis-Malachi](#), chapter 2).

Defining Literary Units

Read carefully and identify introductions, conclusions, and changes of setting, character, or time to find the words that give clues to the narrative's design on the micro-level.

Identifying Repeated Words

Read, re-read, use multiple translations (especially more literal ones) or an interlinear or a concordance, and then re-read some more!

"A 'lead-word' is a word that repeats significantly in a text or group of texts, and by following these repetitions, one is able to decipher or grasp a meaning of the text ... The repetition may not be of the same exact word, but of the word-root ... which intensifies the dynamic action of the repetition ... if you imagine the entire text stretched out before you, you can sense waves moving back and forth between key words, matching the rhythm of the text ... it is one of the most powerful means of conveying meaning."

Buber, Martin (2012). [Schriften zur Bibelübersetzung](#). Gütersloher Verlagshaus. 1131.

An example of repeated words in Jonah is the use of "fear" and "hurl" in chapter 1 and the use of "call out" in chapters 1-3.

"One of the most imposing barriers that stands between modern readers and the imaginative subtlety of the biblical authors is the prominence of repetition. We are accustomed to stories in which repetition is far less obvious, and so this is probably the feature of biblical narrative that looks most 'primitive' to the modern eye ... In order to appreciate the artfulness of this kind of repetition, a modern reader has to cultivate a new, even opposite, set of expectations than what they bring to literary works. Modern stories usually attempt to mimic reality by giving us large amounts of information that is not crucial to the plot, so that one is expected to detect the repetition of key themes and words among lots of other background noise. Biblical narrative is the opposite. Here we are confronted with an extremely spare narrative with a high degree of repetition and similarity, and what we are expected to notice is the small but revealing differences among the sea of similarities. This is how new meanings emerge in pattern of expectations created by explicit repetition."

Alter, Robert (2011). [The Art Of Biblical Narrative](#). Basic Books. 96-97.

Wordplay and Paronomasia

"Biblical authors often employ wordplays upon a name or a play made with sounds, but they also have significant links between stories offered by names and puns ... there is a wide scope of possibilities: sound effects, alliteration, word play, riddles, concealed meanings, key-word motifs. The biblical writers utilize these potentialities within literary units in different ways ... The biblical authors are creative and very

imaginative with this technique, pushing their word and sound associations far beyond the norms of spoken language. Here ‘poetic license’ is indeed the name of the game.”

Garsiel, Moshe (1991). *Biblical Names: A Literary Study of Midrashic Derivations and Puns*. Bar-Ilan University Press. 19-20.

An example of this type of wordplay in Jonah is the use of “go down/sleep/make vows” in chapter 1.

Techniques of Biblical Composition: Juxtaposition

Placing two narratives side by side so that their proximity encourages the reader to compare and contrast their content (see Zakovitch, *Through the Looking Glass: Reflection/Inversion Stories in Genesis*) is called juxtaposition.

An example of juxtaposition from Jonah can be seen in how the phrases “call out” (sailors vs. Jonah in chapters 1-3) and “go down” (sailors’ vows in chapter 1 vs. Jonah’s vows in chapter 2) are used in the story.

Genesis 2-4 as Mutually Interpreting Temptation Narratives

Narratives	Genesis 2-3: Adam and Eve	Genesis 4: Cain and Abel
Human given a significant choice for an unstated reason	2:16-17: “From any tree of the garden you may eat, but from the tree of knowing good and evil you should not eat, because the day you eat from it you will surely die.”	4:5-7: But Yahweh did not regard Cain’s offering, and Cain was very angry ... Yahweh said, “Why are you angry, and why has your face fallen? Isn’t it the case that if you do good , you will be lifted up?”
Human tempted by an animal	3:1: Now the snake was more crafty than any creature of the field ... And he said to the woman, “Did God really say not to eat from any tree in the garden?”	4:7: “But if you don’t do good, sin is crouching at the door , and it’s desire is for you.”
Human gives into temptation with destructive consequences	3:6: When the woman saw that the tree was good for food, and desirable to the eyes, and desirable for gaining wisdom, she took ...	4:5: And Cain was very angry 4:8: And Cain spoke to Abel his brother, and while they were in the field Cain rose up against Abel his brother and murdered him”
God shows up to ask a question	3:9: And God called out to the human and said, “ Where are you (איכה)?”	4:9: And God said to Cain, “ Where is your (אי) brother Abel?”

Genesis 2-4 Temptation Narratives. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

Narratives	Genesis 2-3: Adam and Eve	Genesis 4: Cain and Abel
	3:12: And God said to the woman, " What have you done (מה עשית)?"	4:10: And God said, " What have you done (מה עשית)?"
The human dodges the question	3:12: The human said, "The woman who you set with me, she gave to me and I ate."	4:9: "I don't know! Am I my brother's keeper?"
The perpetrator is cursed	3:14: God said to the serpent, "Because you have done this, you are cursed from every beast and from every creature of the field" 3:17 " Cursed is the ground because of you"	4:11: "And now you are cursed from the ground ..."
Working the ground will now be more difficult	3:17b: "in pain you will eat from the ground " 3:23 And God sent him from the garden of Eden to work the ground .	4:12: "For you will work the ground , and it will no longer give its strength to you."
The human is banished from the divine presence	3:24: And [God] banished the human and he camped east of the garden of Eden ...	4:14: "Behold, you have banished me from the face of the ground and from your presence." 4:16: And Cain settled in the land of Nod, east of Eden .
Genesis 2-4 Temptation Narratives. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).		

In his book, *The Art of Biblical Narrative*, Robert Alter quotes a famous Russian film director in his section on biblical poetry and juxtaposition.

"It remains true to this day, that the juxtaposition of two separate shots by splicing them together resembles not so much a simple sum of one shot plus one shot. Rather, it resembles a new creation. The result is qualitatively distinguishable from each of the elements viewed separately ... This is the effect of the montage: each piece exists no longer as something unrelated, but as a given particular representation of a larger common theme that now penetrates all of the shot-pieces. This juxtaposition of these partial details calls to life and forces into light any general qualities that each piece expresses that might bind them together into a single whole, a single image that the spectator experiences."

Alter, Robert (2011). [The Art Of Biblical Narrative](#). Basic Books. 24.

Reflection Question

What kinds of things should we pay attention to in order to understand a text's literary design? Which of these would be most helpful for you or others in your context?